

UI/UX benchmark: Vinod's Academy community

The useful lesson is orientation. The community site makes the next action visible through grouped navigation, descriptive account choices, progress summaries and short explanations near unfamiliar controls. Marktplaats Watcher can use that clarity in a few places without changing its calmer Sieve design. The highest-value work is clearer account choices and more actionable first-use guidance. This is an idea audit, not a design or implementation approval.

Source: [Vinod's Academy community](#), observed read-only by the station on 4 October 2026. Evidence is the dated [station notes](#); the browser tool could not save screenshots, so there are no image files in this benchmark. The member's name and e-mail are omitted. Judgments about why a pattern works and how it might fit our app are our inferences, not measured outcomes. No source code, assets, logo, colour palette, fonts or long-form copy are reproduced.

Inventory

Element	What they do	Why it works (inference)	Evidence
Sign-in	Split hero explains the offer; a separate card holds Google and e-mail sign-in and recovery.	Gives context while keeping the form easy to find.	Sign-in note
App shell	A dark sidebar groups COMMUNITY, LEARN and MANAGE; an active row and collapse control show place and available space.	Groups reduce scanning; collapse can return room to content.	Shell note
Top bar	Breadcrumb at left; search with 𐄂K , Ask, theme, notification and account controls at right.	Keeps global actions in one predictable area.	Shell note
Account menu	Identity and role badge precede four actions, each with a one-line explanation.	Explains the consequence of choices before a click.	Account note
Home	Greeting, three stats, Continue learning, Upcoming events, Latest updates and From the community.	Puts progress and a next step above recent activity.	Home note
Feed and cards	Type filters and search lead into posts with status pills and Like, Comment, Copy and Save actions.	Makes a mixed stream scannable and repeatable.	Feed note
Events	Upcoming/Past/All, date tiles, capacity and attendance, then calendar and join actions.	Shows when, where and what to do next in one card.	Events note
Videos	A four-step explainer, summary tiles, tree filter, status counts, search and thumbnails.	Answers how progress works before asking users to browse.	Videos note

Element	What they do	Why it works (inference)	Evidence
Empty and zero states	Home and videos keep zero values visible; learning rows say Not started and show the next action.	A zero is meaningful when paired with a route forward. No standalone empty-page treatment was captured.	Home note , Videos note
Floating Feedback	A persistent bottom-right pill offers a short route to feedback; the feed description also points to it.	Makes a help route discoverable in context.	Shell note , Feed note
Typography and spacing	Inter body, Jakarta headings, small uppercase group labels and repeated card padding/radius establish hierarchy.	Repeated sizes make sections feel related.	Measurements
Dark sidebar and light content	Deep sidebar contrasts with near-white content and white cards.	Separates navigation from the work area at a glance.	Measurements

Fit for Marktplaats Watcher

“Adopt” means reuse the interaction idea; “Adapt” means reshape it for our tasks and existing components. Every proposed implementation would use [our design system](#): Geist, warm graphite surfaces, teal `--accent`, and lilac `--tag` only for its existing meanings.

Element	Call and reason	Our screen and design-system mapping
Sign-in split hero and card	Skip. Our landing already explains the product with a concrete scored example; a second full hero and custom credential form would add weight to a short sign-in path.	<code>frontend/src/Landing.jsx</code> keeps its existing <code>--display</code> , <code>--tag</code> , <code>--accent</code> and Clerk modal path (type/colour rules).
Sidebar groups and collapse	Adapt. Clearer grouping could help a long watch/chat list; collapse needs a real density problem before adding a control.	<code>frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx</code> : reuse <code>.nav-section</code> , <code>.nav-item</code> , <code>--sidebar</code> , <code>--fill-strong</code> and <code>--sidebar-w</code> , with the phone tab bar retained (layout).
Top bar search and actions	Skip as a new bar. Desktop already has <code>⌕</code> search in <code>Sidebar.jsx</code> ; phones have a top bar, theme and account control in <code>App.jsx</code> . An Ask button would duplicate the chat entry point.	Keep <code>frontend/src/App.jsx</code> / <code>Sidebar.jsx</code> on <code>--glass</code> , <code>--accent</code> and existing icon buttons (components).
Described account actions	Adapt. The identity-first, explained-action pattern could clarify where profile, theme and privacy controls lead. Clerk currently supplies the account menu, with a separate app theme reset item.	<code>frontend/src/components/AccountButton.jsx</code> , <code>Sidebar.jsx</code> , <code>App.jsx</code> ; reuse <code>.menu</code> , <code>--elevated</code> , <code>--text-2</code> , <code>--radius-lg</code> , <code>--shadow</code> and <code>--touch</code> . Do not imply the member has a role or permission choice we do not offer.
Home dashboard	Adapt. Progress and next-step modules suit an owner dashboard only where the numbers link to records. Personal learning and event modules do not fit the watcher.	<code>frontend/src/views/admin/Overview.jsx</code> : preserve clickable <code>.stat.door</code> ; use <code>--font-mono</code> for counts and <code>--line</code> / <code>--shadow</code> per component rules .

Element	Call and reason	Our screen and design-system mapping
Feed and cards	Skip the social feed. Watcher is about finding and rating listings, not publishing posts. The filter/search pattern already has close equivalents.	<code>frontend/src/views/AlertsView.jsx</code> and <code>components/ListingCard.jsx</code> : retain listing-card links, score reasons, <code>.chip</code> , <code>--accent-soft</code> and <code>card rules</code> .
Event cards	Skip. RSVP, capacity and calendar actions do not map to watches or alerts.	<code>frontend/src/views/AlertsView.jsx</code> : keep listing time and status in <code>--text-2</code> rather than introducing an event-card type (<code>type rules</code>).
Video explainer and progress	Adapt. A compact “how watching works” explanation could help first-use watch setup; viewing-time and course-tree controls do not fit.	<code>frontend/src/views/Onboarding.jsx</code> , <code>views/WatchesView.jsx</code> : use <code>.grouped</code> / <code>.empty-note</code> , <code>--space-*</code> , <code>--text-sm</code> and <code>--accent</code> for the next action (<code>states</code>).
Zero and empty states	Adopt the next-step cue. Alerts already explain when results arrive; first-use and no-match states could more consistently name the next useful action.	<code>frontend/src/views/AlertsView.jsx</code> , <code>views/WatchesView.jsx</code> , <code>components/Sidebar.jsx</code> : keep <code>.empty-note</code> and <code>--text-2</code> ; add a single <code>--accent</code> action only where it truly helps (<code>copy rule</code>).
Floating Feedback	Adapt only if discoverability is shown to be weak. Feedback already exists in the desktop sidebar and beta banner, with a <code>FeedbackSheet</code> ; a permanent floating pill could cover listings on phones.	<code>frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx</code> , <code>App.jsx</code> , <code>views/FeedbackSheet.jsx</code> : reuse <code>.button</code> , <code>--accent</code> , <code>--touch</code> and <code>--z-bars</code> if later tested (<code>layout</code>).
Typography and spacing	Adopt the consistency, not the measurements. Their hierarchy works because it repeats; ours already defines a repeatable scale.	All cited views use Geist <code>--font</code> , <code>--font-mono</code> , <code>--text-*</code> , <code>--space-1</code> – <code>--space-6</code> , <code>--radius*</code> (<code>type, space</code>).
Dark sidebar / light content	Skip. Our light and dark themes are coherent across sidebar and content; a fixed dark sidebar would add another theme boundary.	<code>frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx</code> , <code>App.jsx</code> : retain <code>--sidebar</code> , <code>--bg</code> , <code>--glass</code> , <code>--line</code> in both themes (<code>colour</code>).

Top five changes worth building

Ranked by expected user value relative to implementation effort. These are ready-to-file issue drafts, not work in MW-77. Evidence for the source pattern is linked in each item; the exact user benefit remains a hypothesis until tested.

1. Explain account destinations before selection. Problem: the sidebar account row opens Clerk, while privacy and archive sit beside it, so related destinations are split (`Sidebar.jsx` , `AccountButton.jsx` ; [source account note](#)). Acceptance criteria: present a short description for each available account-related destination; preserve Clerk's actual security/sign-out actions and the current theme behavior; keyboard, touch and screen-reader operation remain usable. Files: `frontend/src/components/AccountButton.jsx` , `frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx` , `frontend/src/App.jsx` , `frontend/src/styles.css` . Use `--elevated` , `--text-2` , `--line` ; validate what Clerk supports before choosing the implementation.
2. Make first-use empty states actionable. Problem: “None yet” in the sidebar gives no path, while the Alerts page has a good explanation but no direct watch action (`Sidebar.jsx` , `AlertsView.jsx` ; [source zero-state notes](#)). Acceptance criteria: first-use Watches and Alerts states say what appears and when; offer one clear create-watch action where relevant; no extra action on populated states; preserve the single-sentence empty-state voice rule. Files: `frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx` , `frontend/src/views/WatchesView.jsx` , `frontend/src/views/AlertsView.jsx` , `frontend/src/styles.css` . Use `.empty-note` , `--text-2` , `--accent` .
3. Explain the watch lifecycle where setup starts. Problem: a new user may not know why the first check is quiet or how scores turn into e-mails (`Landing.jsx` , `Onboarding.jsx` ; [source video explainer note](#)). Acceptance criteria: a short, collapsible explanation near first watch setup covers initial baseline, check schedule, scoring and alert threshold in our words; stays out of the

way after setup; works by keyboard and on phones. Files: `frontend/src/views/Onboarding.jsx` , `frontend/src/components/WatchSheet.jsx` , `frontend/src/styles.css` . Use `--space-*` , `--text-sm` , `--line` and existing disclosure styling.

4. Give the owner dashboard a next-action summary. Problem: its many clickable metrics make inspection possible but do not point to the most urgent review first (`Overview.jsx` ; [source home note](#)). Acceptance criteria: show a small set of existing, actionable review counts at the top; each opens the matching existing drilldown; zero states are explicit; no new metric or data fetch. Files: `frontend/src/views/admin/Overview.jsx` , `frontend/src/styles.css` . Use `.stat.door` , `--font-mono` , `--line` and `--accent` only for the action.
5. Test feedback entry-point discoverability. Problem: the source reinforces Feedback in the shell and feed copy; our entry points are the desktop sidebar and beta banner ([source shell/feed notes](#), `Sidebar.jsx` , `App.jsx`). Acceptance criteria: measure whether users can find Feedback on desktop and phone; if they cannot, add one context-safe entry point that opens the existing `FeedbackSheet` ; verify it does not cover cards, tab bar or sheet controls. Files: `frontend/src/components/Sidebar.jsx` , `frontend/src/App.jsx` , `frontend/src/views/FeedbackSheet.jsx` , `frontend/src/styles.css` . Use `--touch` , `--z-bars` , `--accent` and existing button styles.

What we already do better

- Scores explain themselves. `ListingCard.jsx` and `AlertsView.jsx` show a 0–10 score and its reason, and the landing gives a real scored example. The observed community cards offer status and engagement context, but no analogous decision explanation ([feed note](#); [our card rules](#)).
- Feedback closes into a review loop. `FeedbackSheet.jsx` can attach a privacy-filtered page screenshot and lets users rate alerts; `Overview.jsx` exposes review records. The source observation establishes a visible Feedback route, not what happens after submission ([shell note](#); [our feedback loop](#)).
- Our visual rules are explicit. Teal action semantics, lilac highlight, Geist type, spacing, states, contrast and plain-language rules are documented and checked against `styles.css` ([design system](#)). The source's measured styles are useful reference observations, not a claim about its internal design governance ([measurements](#)).

Limits and credit

This is a single dated observation of the named pages. No interaction study, accessibility audit, responsive measurement or comparison test was captured. “Why it works” and priority are design judgments to validate in separate issues. The source is Vinod's Academy at [community.databag.ai](#); all descriptions are paraphrased except short interface labels. There are no screenshots to blur or distribute.